something and then make it. I want to tell stories. Brands love me for that. You give me a timeline, I will make it happen with no compromise on quality."

The democratic nature of the platforms has given wings to not just Gen Z-ers like Chandni but even Gen Alpha. Aaditya Shukla was 10 when he began making videos on Insta because he had "nothing to do other than studies" during the lockdown. His first earning was Rs 2,000, when his follower count was 10,000. Five years later, he has balanced studies and reel-making to have brands like Domino's wooing him to reach his teenage Insta audience of 1.6 million. Having lost his father in 2018, Shukla is happy to join his two elder siblings in helping his homemaker mother. "I have already built something, I won't have to suffer much later," says Aadi.

And it's not just shorts that sell, long format, too, has an audience of its own, emboldening creators like Raj Shamani to go from 45-minute interviews to 2-3 hour-long ones on his YouTube podcast show, *Figuring Out*. "I don't believe attention spans are getting shorter. I think the ability to judge content is getting faster," he says. The go-to podcaster currently has 50 people working for him in several capacities, allowing him to put out three episodes a week and 25 shorts a day across seven channels and several platforms.

And yet, most agree it's just the start for a young economy (just about 15 years old) that's hard to ignore. "In India, we don't have enough creators with critical mass yet. We are in the stage of building it," says Vinay Pillai, chief business officer at Pocket Aces, which runs Clout, a talent management wing that currently boasts 225 influencers. "Once it manifests itself, where we get creators like Kylie Jenner or Mr Beast, you will see the next step for the creator economy. Monetising the distribution they have built into commerce will radicalise the industry." Pillai believes the next set of creators will be different and interesting, for their inspiration will not be film stars but their own kind. "The best creators even today and 10-15 years from now will be those who take their authentic selves and turn the volume up, not those following trends," he adds.

Artificial Intelligence will change the game even further, aiding the quick delivery of content. Tamil YouTuber Madan Gowri relies on tools like ChatGPT, Google's Gemini and DeepSeek for everything from research and scripting to editing and culling data on the issues that would drive audience engagement. "It has helped me increase viewership," he says. "All we have to do is find the right prompt and curate our content accordingly."

UNDER THEIR INFLUENCE

Trust and authenticity are valued assets in influencers. Here is how they're categorised according to the number of followers

NANO *10-50,000	**MICRO** 50-100,000
CATEGORY C 100-500,00	**CATEGORY B** 500,000-1 mn

MEGA
1 million followers and more

CELEBRITY
Established figures in sports, entertainment, arts etc.

**Number of followers*

The Road Ahead

A growing economy likely calls for greater supervision. Given the influence creators now wield on consumer spend, there's talk of the harm they can wreak on vulnerable audiences, especially children and young adults. The Advertising Standards Council of India's (ASCI) recent Influencer Compliance Scorecard showed that 69 per cent of India's top 100 digital stars failed to meet basic disclosure guidelines in brand collaborations. "This signals a widespread lack of awareness or willingness to comply, risking audience trust and regulatory action," says Manisha Kapoor, CEO & secretary general, ASCI. "Influencer endorsements in sensitive sectors like health, finance, gaming and virtual digital assets pose serious risks to public safety." The body expects influencers to disclose qualifications when promoting technical claims and more vigilance "not just from influencers but also from brands and agencies to prevent irresponsible promotions".

A crowded space of influencers has also meant more competition and creators having to keep their sleeves rolled up all the time. "It looks really easy to do, but difficult to sustain," says Sheth of Monk Entertainment. "Just try building distribution through short-form content for six months. I'll change my name if you don't feel disappointed at some point because you are not getting enough likes or views or don't have scripts to go along. It is a competitive space, because everyone with a phone is a possible creator." Even someone as popular as RJ Karishma, who has a community of millions on both YouTube and Insta, admits feeling the pressure of uncertainty. One month, it's brand deals a dozen, the next not so much. "When I started, there weren't that many creators and I had the power to say this is the amount I charge, I cannot go below this," she says. "Now, we are also compromising. There are more creators, so if not you, they will find somebody else."

Ultimately, it's the community they have built that fuels the creativity and keeps them going. Karishma cannot thank them enough. It was her enactments of saas-bahu characters on social media that earned her a viewership and enabled her to pay the bills for her mother's cancer treatment. "I am grateful to my audience. Because of them, my mother is alive." ■